Chapter Two

The Iron Hand and the Velvet Glove, 1918–1919

INovember 1918, there appeared to be a lot that Britain could be thankful for. The British Empire emerged from the war against the Central Powers not only as a victor but also as a power presiding over a quarter of the world's population. [1] The British imperial army was of a strength not experienced since the Napoleonic Wars, [2] and to many contemporaries the mobilisation of the empire's resources during the conflict had, in the words of Lloyd George, revealed to the world 'that the British Empire was not an abstraction but a living force to be reckoned with'. [3] While the war had seen the demise of three great empires, Britain's was still standing, and its prime minister was about to sit in Paris, as leader of one of the world's greatest nations, to decide the fate of Europe, Asia and Africa. [4] As Curzon put it to the House of Lords in November 1918, 'The British flag has never flown over a more powerful or more united empire.' [5] It is easy, therefore, to see why some contemporaries saw the aftermath of the First World War as a time of confidence and optimism for Britain.

And yet, every silver-lining has its cloud. The war had tested the empire to its very limit, straining Britain's economy and costing millions of lives. The disillusionment of the people against their governments had already created revolution in one major European state and was about to take hold in others. Nationalist and pan-Islamic fervour were simmering in Asia. And, while the rapid increase in imperial territory might be an indication of Britain's power in the post-war period, it also necessitated a requisite increase in military and administrative expense that the country could ill-afford after the strains of the war.

One thing that was for sure was that, for better or worse, the First World War had certainly changed things, as Sir Mark Sykes (expert in all things